

Chapter 183 Part 1: Extra Story 6-1

This meal appeared harmonious on the surface, but in reality, everyone had their own thoughts.

Liang Shi's mind was disturbed by what Gu Yixue had said in the kitchen. While eating, she couldn't help but keep looking at her. Gu Yixue picked at her food with chopsticks for a few bites before putting them down, constantly twirling a cigarette in her hand.

In the past, she would put on an act in front of Shen Fenghe and never took out cigarettes.

Unlike now, completely uninhibited.

She looked very exhausted, with a dejected expression.

Shen Hui even asked with concern, and Gu Yixue laughed lightly, answering casually: "Can't adjust to the jet lag."

But only she herself knew the real situation.

As soon as the meal was over, Liang Shi sent Gu Yixue a message, using the excuse of a script to call her to the study. But the moment she went in, Gu Yixue opened the window and lit a cigarette.

Blue-gray smoke dispersed in the study. Liang Shi kept her distance, not going closer to breathe in secondhand smoke.

"How did you come back from abroad with an even bigger smoking addiction?" Liang Shi asked indirectly.

Gu Yixue exhaled a puff of smoke, turned around and glanced back, raising an eyebrow with a smile: "Filming is too tiring."

It was obvious—Gu Yixue's film was shot on location abroad. What was originally supposed to take half a month had been compressed by her into five days. She must have been running on fumes.

"There's no need to rush like this. You'd still make it even if you took your time. Why push yourself so hard?" Liang Shi asked.

Gu Yixue smiled but didn't say anything.

"If you're asking about what I said earlier." Gu Yixue stubbed out the cigarette, waving her hand to disperse the smoke in front of her, "Don't ask. I don't want to talk about it."

Liang Shi: "....."

She didn't know what to say for a moment.

She was clearly the one who had brought up the topic, yet now she didn't want to talk about it.

She only made Liang Shi, an outsider, worry.

Liang Shi pursed her lips and decided to still try to salvage things for Shen Fenghe's sake. She cleared her throat before saying: "Our family members all seem a bit reserved... You knew her personality when you first met her. She definitely still cares about you."

Hearing this, Gu Yixue laughed out loud, "Playing matchmaker for your sister?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"You're my friend." Liang Shi said helplessly, "To be honest, I don't want to see you two reach this point."

Liang Shi had seen clearly just how much Gu Yixue had given for this relationship.

Rushing to finish filming "Journey of the Heart," then putting on a wedding dress, disregarding the worldly views of others, not caring what anyone said—even if alone, she dared to crash into the wedding venue, all just to marry Shen Fenghe.

But now?

It had only been three years.

It seemed like all the love had been worn away by daily trivialities.

Gu Yixue was completely exhausted.

"I don't know either." Gu Yixue said: "I'll rest for a while first."

Liang Shi couldn't say anything more, only telling her not to shut herself in, and if she wanted someone to drink with, to call her anytime.

Gu Yixue shrugged, "I'll go back and adjust to the time difference first."

"What time difference is there to adjust for someone who hasn't been sleeping anyway?" Liang Shi said knowingly: "Go back and catch up on sleep. Don't ruin your health."

Gu Yixue nodded, then asked if she would be free in a few months—she was planning to film Gu Xingyue's new novel.

"You're pushing yourself that hard?" Liang Shi frowned: "If I remember correctly, the one you have on hand just wrapped. Next you're filming 'A Sky Full of Sparks.' Are you going to adapt that one as soon as you finish this?"

Gu Yixue responded indifferently: "Pretty much."

This kind of back-to-back filming was too damaging.

It hurt not only the body but also inspiration.

Moreover, Gu Yixue was very meticulous in her filming to pursue quality—pulling all-nighters was perfectly normal for her.

Pushing herself so hard... like a rubber band, always stretched so tight, something was bound to snap.

Liang Shi was somewhat worried.

But Gu Yixue didn't want to say more. "I've already gotten Gu Xingyue's manuscript. I'll be writing the script these next few months. Remember to keep your schedule open."

Liang Shi wanted to persuade her to rest, but she yawned, "I'm sleepy, going home to sleep."

Liang Shi: "....."

Unable to find a breakthrough with Gu Yixue, Liang Shi had no choice but to go find Shen Fenghe.

To be honest, even though they had acknowledged their family relationship and she called Shen Fenghe "sister," seeing Shen Fenghe still made her somewhat nervous.

Shen Fenghe naturally carried an aura. Even when relaxed at home, she had already developed that almost mechanical coldness. Even when she occasionally spoke gently to someone, it could still feel like she was being passive-aggressive.

Of course, this was related to Liang Shi's first impression of her.

Even after so many years, it hadn't completely improved.

However, when it came to Shen Fenghe's lifelong happiness, Liang Shi was still brave.

While everyone was busy with the chaos of coaxing the children, Liang Shi handed a cup of warm water to Shen Fenghe, took the opportunity to sit beside her, and pretended to ask casually: "Sis, have you been busy lately?"

Shen Fenghe set the water cup on the table, "It's alright. Is something wrong?"

Liang Shi immediately denied it, "Nothing's wrong with me."

"Alright, if there is, remember to tell me." Shen Fenghe reminded her. Her voice was relatively gentle, much warmer than when she usually spoke to others, but Liang Shi still felt a sense of distance.

Liang Shi was about to probe indirectly when Shen Fenghe's phone rang.

Shen Fenghe frowned the moment she saw the caller ID on the screen, but still gestured to Liang Shi before answering, her voice cold: "What else do you want?"

"Shen Fenghe, help me one more time." The other person said.

The voice came through the receiver to Liang Shi's ears.

It sounded strangely familiar.

Shen Fenghe paused, stood up and walked outside, "I've already helped you once."

It wasn't until Shen Fenghe left that Liang Shi came back to her senses.

The person on the phone was... Gu Chunmian.

Liang Shi wasn't familiar with that person, but when she had caused a scene at the "Journey of the Heart" production set back then, she had left too deep an impression on Liang Shi.

She hadn't expected Shen Fenghe to still be in contact with Gu Chunmian.

Liang Shi felt like she might have glimpsed the reason why Gu Yixue was disheartened and wanted a divorce.

She also didn't really feel like mediating anymore.

Although Shen Fenghe was her sister, Gu Yixue was also her friend.

As a friend, she truly felt sorry for Gu Yixue.

A genius Beta director, with the label of illegitimate daughter that she could never shake off.

To marry Shen Fenghe, her mother's affairs were constantly dredged up and mocked. She had even heard that back then, Gu Chunmian had made a fuss about having her mother's grave moved and her mother's name removed from the family genealogy.

It was only because Gu Yixue had made some unknown deal that she managed to protect it.

The more Liang Shi thought about what Gu Yixue had been through over the years, the sadder she felt.

Gu Yixue's unrequited love should also come to an end now.

It was like walking alone in a dark tunnel, never having seen the light.

Liang Shi's powerful empathy made her think of so many things in an instant. So when Shen Fenghe returned after finishing her call, Liang Shi still had tears glistening in her eyes, and her gaze toward Shen Fenghe was full of indignation.

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Shen Fenghe looked confused, her brow furrowed tightly: "What's wrong? Who bullied you?"

She had the air of "just say the word and I'll go beat that person to death for you."

Liang Shi stood up, "No one bullied me. Sis, you should think about who you've been bullying."

Secretly venting anger on behalf of Gu Yixue.

Shen Fenghe: "?"

Later, Shen Hui secretly asked Liang Shi, "What's going on? Did big sis upset you?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "I thought of Director Gu and felt upset."

Shen Hui: "....."

Shen Hui only glanced at Shen Fenghe, who was still staring at her phone handling matters, and shook her head to herself: "Our sister is missing a romantic bone in her body."

Liang Shi: "?"

So Shen Hui told Liang Shi about Shen Fenghe's glorious exploits from her school days.

In high school, a boy had given Shen Fenghe a love letter—a pink letter—and also sent her roses. The result was that Shen Fenghe beat him so badly he was hospitalized.

Shen Hui asked her why.

Shen Fenghe righteously said it was the boy who had challenged her to a fight first, and she had merely accepted the challenge.

Her reasoning was that the pink letter contained the line: "Meet me on the school rooftop. I'll be waiting!"

And the roses had thorns, which was clearly a sneak attack.

After that, rumors spread throughout the school that whoever liked Shen Fenghe, Shen Fenghe would beat them up.

And so she remained gloriously single until marriage.

Although she had an engagement with Gu Chunmian, it was all arranged by the family.

To be precise, it was Shen Fenghe who had set it herself. She and Gu Chunmian could be considered childhood sweethearts, knowing each other inside and out.

After finishing her story, Shen Hui sighed: "Only sister-in-law could put up with her—a woman who works overtime six out of seven days a week."

Liang Shi: "....."

Was there a possibility that sister-in-law couldn't put up with her anymore either?

Just as she was thinking this, Xu Qingzhu, who had been eavesdropping, leaned over and whispered: "Dr. Zhao is so fussy, but don't you still really like her?"

Shen Hui: "?"

A few seconds later, Shen Hui resigned herself to fate, "That's true."

Zhao Xuning appeared out of nowhere like a ghost, and flicked the back of Xu Qingzhu's head directly. The flick caught Xu Qingzhu off guard, and she exclaimed while covering the back of her head.

Zhao Xuning scoffed lightly: "You're really good at talking, aren't you."

Pure passive-aggressiveness.

Seeing this, Liang Shi immediately pulled Xu Qingzhu over, raising her hand to rub the back of Xu Qingzhu's head. She glanced sideways at Zhao Xuning and mimicked her tone passive-aggressively: "You're really good at doing things too, aren't you."

Zhao Xuning was unfazed: "I guess."

Liang Shi saw that Xu Qingzhu was still frowning and asked gently: "Does it still hurt?"

Xu Qingzhu wasn't really in pain—after all, Zhao Xuning hadn't used force—but since Liang Shi was worried, she looked at Liang Shi with an aggrieved expression, her eyes like a little puppy's, pitiful: "It hurts~"

Even Zhao Xuning couldn't stand it, "I didn't even use force."

"You're strong." Liang Shi retorted, then called out to Shen Hui: "Second sister, look at her."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

"Liang Shi." Zhao Xuning called her name through gritted teeth, "You're really such a dog... hiss....."

The moment "dog" left her mouth, Zhao Xuning's waist was pinched by Shen Hui, making her gasp in pain.

Zhao Xuning put her hand over Shen Hui's, pleading: "A-Hui."

Shen Hui kicked her again, "If she's a dog, what am I? And what are you? Zhao Xuning, you're really good at talking, aren't you."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

Liang Shi buried her head in Xu Qingzhu's shoulder, laughing uncontrollably.

Xu Qingzhu raised her hand and stroked her hair.

Zhao Xuning was still explaining to Shen Hui that "dog" referred to behavior, not species.

Shen Hui knew that too, but she just wouldn't let Zhao Xuning off.

Zhao Xuning helplessly pressed her forehead, looking at Liang Shi through gritted teeth, but Liang Shi just blinked at her with an innocent expression.

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"You really are something." Zhao Xuning said: "Liang Shi, you're really something else."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow: "Still being fierce with me, huh?"

Zhao Xuning: "?"

"Are you three years old?" Zhao Xuning said to her.

Liang Shi was hugging Xu Qingzhu from behind, her head resting on her shoulder, and casually asked: "Wife, what do you think?"

Zhao Xuning: "....."

Xu Qingzhu laughed lightly: "Dr. Zhao can't get the upper hand and is upset. Let's ignore her."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

"Zhao Xuning." Shen Hui called her: "Go check on your daughter quick, she's about to tear the house apart."

Zhao Xuning immediately ran over, only to see Doubao holding Liang Shi's Best Actress trophy, wobbling as she walked, but grinning foolishly while clutching it.

"Come here." Gu Yixue was sitting on the single sofa in the living room. Finding Doubao's appearance amusing, she beckoned to her, "Come to Auntie."

Zhao Xuning went over to take the trophy from Doubao's hands, but Doubao wouldn't give it up at all. The moment Zhao Xuning tried to grab it, she would pout and look ready to cry.

The trophy had sharp edges, and Zhao Xuning was afraid of hurting Doubao if she snatched it forcefully, so she felt a bit helpless.

Doubao also knew it wasn't safe around Zhao Xuning, so when Gu Yixue beckoned to her, she happily toddled over.

Zhao Xuning turned to look at Shen Hui. Shen Hui glared at her: "Look at your daughter, so naughty."

Zhao Xuning: ".....You gave birth to her."

Shen Hui: ".....She takes after you."

Zhao Xuning was helpless. Looking at her, she smiled, "Fine, whatever you say is right."

Liang Shi covered her cheek, "Ah~ my teeth are going to fall out from all this sweetness."

But then she got glared at by Zhao Xuning.

Liang Shi immediately said: "Second sister, look, she's glaring at me."

Shen Hui: "Her eyesight is bad."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

After Doubao ran over to Gu Yixue, she directly nestled into Gu Yixue's arms.

Someone with such gorgeous looks shouldn't match the style of a child at all, but this scene was strangely harmonious.

Then they heard Gu Yixue coaxing Doubao: "Come on, baby, give this to Auntie. Your little auntie only has this one Best Actress trophy. Auntie has plenty at home—I'll give you some to smash and play with."

Liang Shi: "???"

Was this the prestige of an internationally renowned director?